

THE BEGINNER'S COMPLETE GUIDE TO

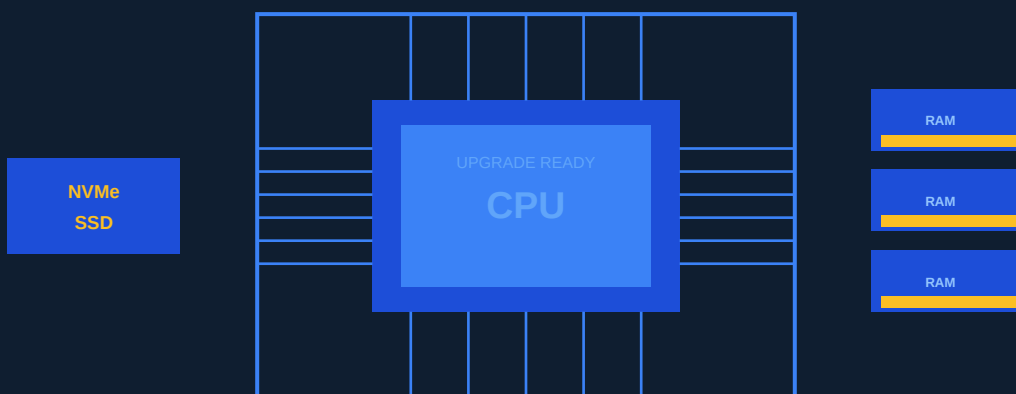
Upgrade Your Own PC

RAM • SSD • GPU • Compatibility • Step-by-Step Installs

SAVE HUNDREDS

NO EXPERIENCE NEEDED

STEP-BY-STEP



Stop paying shop prices — upgrade it yourself and keep the savings

Compatible with Windows 10 & 11 Desktops and Laptops

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Why Upgrading Beats Buying New

The money-saving secret most people don't know about

Here's something that surprises most people: the PC that's been frustrating you for years might not need to be replaced. It might just need one or two targeted upgrades — upgrades that cost a fraction of a new computer and take less than an hour to do yourself.

A computer repair shop might charge \$150–\$200 just to install more RAM. That same RAM stick might cost you \$25 online — and snapping it in takes about two minutes. This guide teaches you how to do every major PC upgrade yourself, from buying the right part to physically installing it without breaking anything.

What this guide covers:

- RAM upgrades — give your PC more working memory so it stops freezing up
- SSD upgrades — replace a slow old hard drive with something dramatically faster
- GPU upgrades — better graphics for gaming, video editing, and creative work
- Bonus upgrades — cooling fans, power supplies, and Wi-Fi cards explained
- A full shopping guide — how to find the right part for your specific PC
- How to sell your old parts and recover some of your upgrade costs

You don't need any prior experience. You don't need special tools beyond a screwdriver. And you definitely don't need to spend \$800 on a new PC. Let's get started.

How Much Can You Actually Save?

Upgrade	What a Shop Charges	What You'll Pay DIY	Your Savings
RAM Upgrade (8GB to 16GB)	\$150–\$200	\$25–\$50	~\$150
Hard Drive to SSD Swap	\$200–\$300	\$60–\$100	~\$180
GPU Upgrade	\$250–\$400	\$150–\$300	~\$120
Full Upgrade (RAM + SSD)	New PC: \$600–\$900	DIY: \$100–\$150	~\$600+

TIP: You don't have to do every upgrade at once. Most people start with RAM or SSD — pick whichever one matches your biggest frustration and start there.

Understanding What's Inside Your PC

A plain-English tour of the parts that matter

Before you buy anything or open your PC, you need to know what the main components actually do. We're only covering what's relevant to upgrading — just enough to shop with confidence.

The Five Parts You Need to Know About

CPU (Processor)	The brain of your computer. It handles all calculations and instructions. You can't upgrade this without also replacing the motherboard in most PCs — so we leave it alone. But knowing what CPU you have matters for compatibility checks.
RAM (Memory)	Temporary working space your PC uses right now. More RAM means more programs open at once without slowdown. One of the easiest and cheapest upgrades you can make. Think of it like your desk — the bigger the desk, the more you can spread out.
Storage Drive	Where everything is permanently saved — your files, Windows, all your programs. Old computers use slow spinning hard drives (HDDs). Modern SSDs are 5–10x faster. Swapping to an SSD is often the single most dramatic upgrade you can make.
GPU (Graphics Card)	Handles everything visual — games, video playback, 3D graphics. Basic PCs have a GPU built into the CPU (called 'integrated graphics'). Adding a dedicated graphics card unlocks much better performance for gaming and creative work.
Motherboard	The main circuit board everything plugs into. You won't upgrade this directly, but it determines what RAM, GPU, and storage your PC can accept. We'll check your motherboard specs in Chapter 2.

Desktop vs. Laptop: What's Different?

Most upgrades work on both desktops and laptops, but laptops have some important limitations:

Component	Desktop	Laptop
RAM	Usually upgradeable	Some laptops have soldered RAM — check first
Storage	Almost always upgradeable	Most laptops have an upgradeable SSD
GPU	Easy to upgrade	Almost always built in — not upgradeable
CPU	Possible but rarely worth it	Soldered on — not upgradeable

NOTE: If you have a laptop and want better graphics, an external GPU dock (eGPU) is an option — but it's expensive and complex. We briefly cover it in Chapter 5.

How to Check What Your PC Can Handle

Do this before you buy a single thing

This is the most important chapter in the guide. Buying the wrong part is the #1 beginner mistake. A \$40 RAM stick that's the wrong type is completely useless in your PC. The good news: checking compatibility is free and takes about five minutes.

Method 1: Crucial's Free Scanner (Easiest)

1**Visit [crucial.com](https://www.crucial.com) and click 'Advisor'**

Go to [crucial.com](https://www.crucial.com) — look for 'System Advisor' or 'Memory Advisor'

This is a free, trusted tool made by one of the top RAM and SSD manufacturers

2**Download and run the scanner**

It's a tiny program that scans your PC's specs in about 30 seconds

No installation required — run it, let it scan, then close it

3**Read your results**

The scanner shows exactly what RAM and SSD types your PC supports

It lists specific products guaranteed to be compatible

You don't have to buy from Crucial — you're just using the information

Method 2: Look Up Your PC Model Manually

1**Find your computer's model name**

Desktop: look for a sticker on the case, or check your purchase receipt

Laptop: look on the bottom for a model number sticker

Or press Windows key + Pause/Break to see your System info

2**Search '[your model] specs' online**

Example: search 'Dell OptiPlex 7090 specs' or 'HP Pavilion 15-eh1 specs'

Go to the manufacturer's official site — they list exactly what RAM type it uses

3

Write down these four things

RAM type: DDR3? DDR4? DDR5?

Maximum RAM the motherboard supports (e.g. 'up to 64GB')

Number of RAM slots (usually 2 or 4)

Storage type: SATA? NVMe M.2? 2.5-inch bay?

Method 3: Check Inside Windows Right Now

See current RAM	Windows key + R, type 'msinfo32', press Enter — look for 'Installed Physical Memory'
RAM type and speed	Task Manager (Ctrl+Shift+Esc) then Performance tab then Memory
Storage type	Task Manager then Performance tab then Disk — shows SSD or HDD
Graphics card	Task Manager then Performance tab then GPU

WATCH OUT: Don't skip this chapter and guess. RAM has to match your motherboard's exact type or it won't work at all. Five minutes here saves you a frustrating return shipment.

Upgrading Your RAM

More speed, more multitasking — one of the easiest upgrades you can make

RAM (Random Access Memory) is your computer's short-term workspace. Every time you open Chrome, a Word document, or Spotify, it uses up RAM. When you run out, your PC starts using your hard drive as a backup — and that's when everything slows to a crawl.

Signs you need more RAM:

- Your computer slows down when multiple programs are open
- Browser tabs reload when you switch between them
- Your PC is slow even though your hard drive has plenty of free space
- Task Manager shows 80%+ memory usage during normal everyday tasks

How Much RAM Do You Need?

Current RAM	Our Recommendation	Why
4GB or less	Upgrade immediately	Barely usable with Windows 11 — upgrade to at least 16GB
8GB	Consider upgrading	Fine for basic tasks, but 16GB is noticeably smoother
16GB	You're fine	Sweet spot for most users — gaming, browsing, office work
32GB+	No upgrade needed	Only needed for video editing, 3D work, heavy multitasking

RAM Types — You Must Get the Right One

RAM comes in different generations. You **MUST** match your motherboard's type. They are physically different shapes and simply won't fit in the wrong slot — which is a good thing.

Type	Era	Found In	Typical Speed	Status
DDR3	2007–2014	Older PCs	1333–2133 MHz	Being phased out
DDR4	2014–2021	Most current PCs	2133–3600 MHz	Most common

DDR5	2021–now	Newest PCs	4800 MHz+	Faster but pricier
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TIP: DDR4 RAM physically cannot fit in a DDR3 slot (or vice versa) — the notch is in a different position. This safety design means you can't accidentally install the wrong type.

What to Look for When Buying RAM

Capacity: How much the stick holds. Get 16GB total minimum — usually two 8GB sticks. If adding to existing RAM rather than replacing, match what's already installed.

Speed (MHz): Higher is faster, but your motherboard has a speed limit. Buying faster RAM than your board supports is fine — it runs at the board's max. DDR4-3200 is a great all-round choice.

Kit vs. Single: RAM works best in pairs (called 'dual-channel'). A 2x8GB kit outperforms a single 16GB stick and usually costs the same. Check your motherboard manual for which slots to use together.

Brand: Crucial, Kingston, Corsair, and G.Skill are all solid. Avoid no-name brands with suspiciously low prices — fake or misrepresented RAM is common.

Installing RAM — Step by Step

TOOLS NEEDED: Phillips-head screwdriver (to open the case only)

1

Shut down and unplug completely

Fully shut down — not sleep mode

Unplug the power cable and press the power button once to discharge any electricity

Laptops: remove the battery too if it's removable

2

Ground yourself against static

Touch a metal part of the PC case before handling any components

Or wear an anti-static wrist strap (\$5 online — optional but recommended)

Static electricity is the #1 cause of accidental component damage

3

Open the case

Desktop: usually 1–2 screws on the back panel, then slide the side panel off

Laptop: remove the small screws from the bottom panel — put them in a bowl so none roll away

Take a photo before you open anything so you remember what goes where

4

Find the RAM slots

Long thin slots near the CPU — you'll see the existing RAM sticks installed in them
Look for the small plastic clips at each end of the slots
Check your manual for which slots to use — often labeled A1, A2, B1, B2

5

Remove old RAM (if replacing, not just adding)

Press down on both plastic clips at the same time — the stick will pop up slightly
Hold the RAM by its edges only — never touch the gold contacts
Pull it straight up and out

6

Install the new RAM

Line up the notch on the RAM with the notch in the slot — it only fits one way
Press down firmly and evenly on both ends until you hear a click
The plastic clips should snap back by themselves
If it won't click, check the notch alignment — don't force it

7

Close up and test

Put the case back together, plug everything back in, and power on
Windows automatically detects the new RAM — no drivers needed
Verify in Task Manager then Performance then Memory — you'll see the new total

TIP: If your PC won't start after a RAM install, the stick probably isn't fully seated. Shut down, unplug, and press it in more firmly — this is the most common installation mistake.

Upgrading to an SSD

The single biggest speed boost you can give any old computer

If your computer takes 3–5 minutes to boot up, a slow hard drive is why. Old spinning hard drives (HDDs) have physical moving parts that have to spin up and find data. A modern SSD has no moving parts and reads data almost instantly. This is the upgrade that makes old computers feel brand new.

How dramatic is the difference?

- Windows startup: 3–5 minutes (HDD) vs 15–20 seconds (SSD)
- Opening Chrome: 8–12 seconds vs under 2 seconds
- File copying speed: 80 MB/s (HDD) vs 500–7000 MB/s (NVMe SSD)
- Overall feel: Night and day — you'll notice the difference immediately

Three Types of SSD — Which Fits Your PC?

Type	What it Looks Like	Fits In...	Speed	Cost	Verdict
2.5" SATA	Flat box like a small book	2.5" laptop bay or desktop bay	~500 MB/s	\$40–\$80	Good
M.2 SATA	Stick the size of a piece of gum	M.2 slot on motherboard	~550 MB/s	\$35–\$70	Good
M.2 NVMe	Same size, different protocol	M.2 NVMe-compatible slot	2000–7000 MB/s	\$50–\$120	Best

TIP: Check your PC's specs page (from Chapter 2) to see which type fits. You'll see whether it has a 2.5" drive bay, an M.2 slot, and whether that slot supports NVMe.

What Size SSD Should You Get?

The most common mistake is buying too small. Here's a simple guide:

Size	Is it Enough?	Notes
250GB	Too tight	Windows alone takes ~30GB. Very little room left over.

500GB	Minimum	Fine if you store photos and videos on an external drive.
1TB	Recommended	Plenty of room for most users. Best value per gigabyte.
2TB+	Power users	Video editors, large game libraries, content creators.

Clone Your Drive or Start Fresh?

There are two ways to move to your new SSD. Choose based on what you want:

Option A: Clone Your Drive Keep all your files and settings as-is	Option B: Fresh Windows Install Start clean with a new installation
- All files, programs, and settings transfer automatically - Windows stays activated - Takes 30–90 minutes total - Needs a USB adapter cable (~\$10) or M.2 enclosure (~\$15) - Best if you don't want to reinstall everything - Free tool: Macrium Reflect Free (macrium.com)	- Everything starts fresh and clean - Good chance to remove old bloatware - Requires a Windows USB drive (free to make at microsoft.com) - You'll need to reinstall your programs afterward - Best if Windows has been slow or buggy for a long time - Free tool: Download Windows from microsoft.com/software-download

Installing Your SSD — Step by Step

TOOLS NEEDED: Phillips screwdriver | USB adapter or M.2 enclosure (for cloning)

1

Back up your files first — always

Copy important files to an external drive or cloud storage
Even though cloning is generally safe, old drives can fail mid-clone
This is your safety net — never skip it

2

Connect new SSD as an external drive

2.5" SATA SSD: plug into a USB-to-SATA adapter, then connect via USB
M.2 SSD: put it in an M.2 enclosure, then plug in via USB
Your PC should show it as a new external drive

3

Clone your old drive (skip if doing fresh install)

Download and open Macrium Reflect Free

Click 'Clone this disk' — select old drive as source, new SSD as destination

Start the clone — it takes 30–90 minutes depending on how much data you have

4

Physically swap the drives

Desktop: unscrew old drive from its bay, install new SSD in same spot

Laptop: open bottom panel, disconnect old drive, connect new SSD

For M.2: slide it into the slot at an angle and screw down the retention screw

5

Boot up and verify

Cloned drive: Windows starts normally — just much faster

Fresh install: boot from Windows USB and follow the setup wizard

Check Windows activation: Settings then System then Activation

6

What to do with your old drive

Keep it! Format it fully and use it as extra storage inside or outside the PC

Or see Chapter 8 for how to sell it and recover some money

WATCH OUT: If your PC doesn't boot after the swap, change the boot order in BIOS. Restart and press F2, F12, or Delete during startup. Go to Boot settings and set your new SSD as the first boot device.

Upgrading Your GPU

Better graphics for gaming, video editing, and creative work

Your graphics card (GPU) handles everything visual on your screen. A basic PC uses 'integrated graphics' — a small GPU built into the CPU chip. Adding a dedicated graphics card is like trading a bicycle for a sports car when it comes to visual performance.

When should you upgrade your GPU?

- You want to play games but your PC struggles or looks terrible
- Video editing, 3D rendering, or photo work feels sluggish
- You use programs like DaVinci Resolve, Blender, or Adobe Premiere regularly
- Your games run but only at low settings or choppy framerates

NOTE: If you mainly browse the web, use documents, or watch video — a GPU upgrade won't help much. RAM and SSD upgrades will. GPU is specifically for graphics-intensive work.

NVIDIA vs. AMD: Which Brand?

These are the two main GPU makers. Both are excellent. Here's a quick comparison:

	NVIDIA (GeForce)	AMD (Radeon)
Gaming performance	Excellent	Excellent — often better value
Special features	DLSS AI upscaling, CUDA for some Adobe apps	FSR open-standard upscaling, works on more games
Driver reliability	Very reliable	Good — improved significantly in recent years
Value for money	Premium pricing	Often 10–20% cheaper for same performance
Best for...	DLSS users or CUDA-dependent apps	Best price-to-performance ratio shoppers

Before You Buy: Check These Four Things

PCIe x16 Slot	Your motherboard needs a PCIe x16 slot — the long slot near the center. Almost all desktops made after 2010 have one. Open your case and look, or check your motherboard specs.
Power Supply Wattage	The most overlooked factor. Check your PSU's wattage label inside the case. Budget GPUs need 400W minimum. Mid-range cards need 550W+. High-end needs 750W+. If your PSU is too weak, upgrade it before the GPU.
Physical Case Space	Measure inside your case. High-end GPUs can be 300mm+ long and take up 2–3 slots of width. Check your case's maximum GPU length spec — usually listed in the case manual or product page.
Power Connectors	Mid and high-end GPUs need 6-pin or 8-pin power cables from your PSU. Check that your power supply has these cables. Some newer GPUs use a 16-pin connector with an adapter included in the box.

GPU Recommendations by Budget

Budget	Recommended Cards	What You Can Do
Under \$150	RX 6600 (used)	1080p gaming at medium-high, HD video editing
\$150–\$250	RTX 3060 or RX 7600	1080p gaming at high-ultra, 4K video editing
\$250–\$400	RTX 4060 Ti or RX 7700 XT	1440p gaming, fast creative work
\$400–\$600	RTX 4070 or RX 7800 XT	High-end 1440p, light 4K gaming
\$600+	RTX 4080 / RTX 4090	4K gaming, professional 3D and VFX work

NOTE: The used GPU market offers exceptional value. A used RTX 3070 for \$180–\$200 outperforms many new \$250 budget cards. Check eBay, Reddit's r/hardwareswap, and Facebook Marketplace.

Installing a GPU — Step by Step

1

Shut down, unplug, open the case

Full shutdown — not sleep mode

Unplug the power cable and press the power button to discharge electricity

Remove the side panel

2

Remove the slot cover or old GPU

Old GPU: unplug power cables, press the PCIe retention latch, pull the card out

No GPU yet: remove the metal slot cover(s) at the back of the case (usually 1–2 screws)

Save the screws — you'll use them to secure the new GPU bracket

3

Insert the new GPU

Line up the gold contacts with the PCIe x16 slot

Press down firmly until you hear a definite click — the latch snaps

Screw the bracket into the case with the screws from before

4

Connect power cables

Plug the 6-pin or 8-pin PCIe cables from your PSU into the GPU

Some GPUs need two connectors — check the documentation that came with it

The cables only connect one way — don't force them

5

Boot and install drivers

Start Windows normally

NVIDIA: go to [nvidia.com](https://www.nvidia.com) then Drivers and download for your exact model

AMD: go to [amd.com](https://www.amd.com) then Drivers and Support

Restart after installation is complete

6

Verify everything is working

Task Manager then Performance then GPU — your new card should be listed there

Make sure your monitor cable is plugged into the new GPU, not the motherboard

Launch a game or run a benchmark to confirm performance

Other Upgrades Worth Considering

Quick wins and quality-of-life improvements

Beyond RAM, SSD, and GPU, there are a handful of smaller upgrades that can make a real difference to your experience. These are cheaper, simpler, and often overlooked.

Wi-Fi Card Est: \$25–\$60	If your desktop has poor Wi-Fi or none at all, a PCIe Wi-Fi card is an easy fix. Wi-Fi 6 cards cost \$25–\$60 and take five minutes to install. Windows usually finds drivers automatically. A huge upgrade if you're currently running on an old Wi-Fi adapter.
Cooling Fans / CPU Cooler Est: \$20–\$80	If your PC sounds like a jet engine or slows down under heavy use (called thermal throttling), better cooling helps. Case fans are \$10–\$20 each. A quality aftermarket CPU cooler like a Noctua or be quiet! model keeps temperatures down, which means better sustained performance.
Power Supply (PSU) Est: \$60–\$120	If you're planning a GPU upgrade, check your PSU wattage first. A quality 650W PSU from EVGA, Corsair, or Seasonic covers most mid-range builds. Look for 80+ Bronze or Gold rating. Don't cheap out — a failing PSU can damage every component connected to it.
Extra Storage Drive Est: \$0–\$45	After adding an SSD, your old hard drive doesn't have to go to waste. Keep it installed as a second drive for photos, videos, and backups. Or add a new 2TB HDD (\$40–\$45) alongside your fast SSD — the SSD handles Windows and programs, the HDD handles everything else.
USB Hub or USB PCIe Card Est: \$20–\$50	Running out of USB ports is surprisingly common. A powered USB hub (\$20–\$30) gives you four or more extra ports. For a permanent solution, a PCIe USB card installs inside your desktop and adds full-speed USB 3.0 ports without any speed reduction.

TIP: If your PC is more than 8–10 years old and needs several things upgraded at once, it might be worth doing the maths on a refurbished PC instead. Chapter 7 helps you work that out.

Your Complete Upgrade Shopping Guide

Where to buy, what to avoid, and how to get the best deal

You know what you need. Now let's make sure you buy the right part, from the right place, at the right price.

Where to Buy

Amazon Good	Huge selection, fast shipping, easy returns. Filter for 'Fulfilled by Amazon' to avoid slow third-party sellers. Competitive prices on RAM and SSDs.
Newegg Best for PC parts	PC components specialist — massive selection, frequent sales, often lowest prices. Check 'Combo deals' for bundle savings on related parts.
Best Buy Good for urgent needs	Same-day pickup if you need something today. Prices slightly higher, but return policy is strong and there's no shipping wait.
Facebook Marketplace Used parts	Excellent for GPUs, RAM, and full PCs. Test before paying. Meet in a public place. Save 30–60% vs buying new.
eBay Used parts	Good for used GPUs and older hardware. Buy from sellers with 99%+ feedback. PayPal purchase protection covers most issues.
AliExpress / Temu Avoid	Frequent counterfeits and misrepresented specs. RAM and SSD capacities are often faked. Not worth the risk for components going inside your PC.

Free Tools for Getting the Best Price

Tool	Covers	Best For
camelcamelcamel.com	Amazon	Shows price history — tells you if today's 'sale' is actually a real discount
pcpartpicker.com	Multiple stores	Compares prices across Newegg, Amazon, and B&H; automatically

nowinstock.net	Multiple stores	Alerts you when out-of-stock GPUs come back in stock
slickdeals.net	All stores	Community-posted deals — check before any big purchase

TIP: RAM and SSD prices drop significantly during Black Friday, Amazon Prime Day, and back-to-school season in August. If you can wait a few weeks, those sales are genuine.

Warranty Guide — Know What You're Covered For

RAM: Lifetime warranty from Crucial, Kingston, Corsair, G.Skill. Genuinely honored.

SSD: 3–5 years. Crucial and Samsung are known for straightforward warranty claims.

GPU: 3 years typically. Register your card after purchase to activate the full warranty.

PSU: 5–10 years from quality brands like Seasonic, EVGA, Corsair. This really matters.

Selling Your Old Parts

Recover your upgrade costs — your old hardware is worth more than you think

When you upgrade, you end up with old parts you no longer need. Don't throw them away. Old RAM, hard drives, and graphics cards all have a market. You can often recover 20–50% of your upgrade cost by selling what you replace.

What Your Old Parts Are Typically Worth

Part	Typical Sale Price	How Easy to Sell
DDR4 RAM, 8GB stick	\$8–\$20	Good — sells quickly
DDR4 RAM, 16GB stick	\$20–\$40	Excellent — high demand
DDR3 RAM (any)	\$3–\$10	Low — older generation
HDD, 1TB working	\$10–\$25	Moderate — HDDs less popular now
HDD, 2TB+ working	\$20–\$45	Better — larger sizes still move
SATA SSD, 500GB	\$20–\$40	Good value for buyers
Used mid-range GPU	\$40–\$150	Best seller — always demand for budget gaming
Working older laptop	\$50–\$200	Sells well on Facebook Marketplace

Best Platforms for Selling

Facebook Marketplace (Local — no shipping): Best for hard drives, RAM, and complete PCs. No fees. List with photos, reply fast, meet at a coffee shop or library. Bring a working laptop to test parts on the spot.

eBay (Ship anywhere): Great for GPUs and RAM. Takes 10–13% in fees. Always ship with tracking and photograph everything before sending — protects you if a buyer claims the item was not as described.

Reddit r/hardwareswap (PC enthusiast buyers): Less haggling and fewer lowball offers than general platforms. Post with [H] for 'have' and [W] for 'want'. Building reputation here makes future sales easier.

Craigslist (Local backup option): Works for local sales but higher no-show rate. Always meet in public, cash only. Use as a backup if Facebook Marketplace isn't working for you.

How to List Your Parts for a Fast Sale

1

Test everything before listing

RAM: run MemTest86 (free download) — it checks for errors overnight

HDDs: run CrystalDiskInfo (free) — look for 'Good' health status

GPUs: run FurMark benchmark — if it doesn't crash after 15 minutes, it works

2

Clean the parts

Blow out dust with compressed air (\$5 at any pharmacy or office supply store)

Wipe fingerprints with a dry microfibre cloth

Clean parts photograph better and sell at higher prices

3

Take good photos

Use natural daylight from a window — avoid harsh overhead lighting

Photograph the label showing model, capacity, and speed

Show multiple angles including any scratches, scuffs, or signs of wear

4

Write a clear, honest listing

State the model, capacity, speed, and condition

Mention how long you owned it and why you're selling

Include your test results — 'MemTest passed, zero errors' increases buyer confidence

TIP: Always disclose if something has issues. Dishonest listings lead to disputes and refunds that cost you more than the part was worth. Buyers appreciate honesty and often still buy.

Quick Reference Checklists

Print these out and keep them handy during your upgrades

Before Any Upgrade

- ☐ Back up important files to an external drive or cloud storage
- ☐ Run compatibility check — Crucial Advisor or manual model lookup
- ☐ Note down your RAM type, max capacity, and storage type
- ☐ Order the correct part with free returns in case something is wrong
- ☐ Gather tools: Phillips screwdriver, anti-static wrist strap (optional)
- ☐ Clear a clean, well-lit workspace with a bowl for small screws

RAM Installation Checklist

- ☐ RAM type confirmed (DDR3 / DDR4 / DDR5?)
- ☐ Capacity does not exceed motherboard maximum
- ☐ PC fully shut down and unplugged
- ☐ Touched metal case to discharge any static
- ☐ Old RAM removed if replacing (not just adding)
- ☐ New RAM aligned with notch and pressed in until both clips clicked
- ☐ Case closed, PC powered on
- ☐ Task Manager then Memory confirms new correct total

SSD Installation Checklist

- ☐ Files backed up to external drive
- ☐ SSD type confirmed — SATA 2.5-inch or M.2 NVMe?
- ☐ Clone software downloaded (Macrium Reflect Free) if cloning
- ☐ New SSD connected externally and recognized by PC
- ☐ Clone completed successfully with no errors
- ☐ Old drive removed, new SSD physically installed
- ☐ PC boots to Windows normally

- ☐ Windows activation verified: Settings then System then Activation
- ☐ Old drive formatted and repurposed or ready to sell

GPU Installation Checklist

- ☐ PSU wattage is sufficient for the new GPU
- ☐ PCIe x16 slot confirmed available on motherboard
- ☐ Case dimensions checked — new GPU fits physically
- ☐ Correct power cables (6-pin or 8-pin) available on PSU
- ☐ PC fully shut down and unplugged
- ☐ Old GPU removed if applicable
- ☐ New GPU seated firmly — click heard from PCIe latch
- ☐ Power cables connected to GPU
- ☐ Monitor plugged into new GPU, not motherboard
- ☐ NVIDIA or AMD drivers downloaded and installed
- ☐ GPU visible in Task Manager then Performance then GPU

Common Problems and Quick Fixes

PC won't start after RAM install	RAM not fully seated. Unplug, remove both sticks, and press them in firmly until you hear the click.
RAM total is wrong in Windows	One stick may not be seated properly. Also check BIOS — it reports RAM before Windows loads.
PC doesn't boot after SSD swap	Change boot order in BIOS. Press F2, F12, or Delete at startup then go to Boot and set new SSD first.
Windows shows as not activated	Settings then Activation then Troubleshoot. Or call Microsoft's free activation line.
GPU not showing up in Windows	Check it's fully seated in the PCIe slot and power cables are connected. Install drivers from manufacturer.
PC beeps when powered on	Usually a RAM issue. One long beep and two short = RAM error. Reseat all RAM sticks.

System feels slower after SSD clone

The SSD partition may not be sized correctly. Check Disk Management — SSD should show 100% allocated.

Well done. Whether you upgraded your RAM, swapped in an SSD, or installed a new GPU, you've just saved yourself real money and learned a skill most people never bother with. Your PC will feel different. Share this guide with anyone who is still paying a shop to do what you now know how to do yourself.